

Checklist

Managing Managers Checklist

1. Stay close enough to know what is really happening

- ☐ I have a regular cadence with each manager on goals, risks, delivery, and people issues.
- ☐ I follow up on small signals until I understand whether they matter.
- ☐ I know the status of hiring, coaching, goal-setting, postmortems, and major incidents across teams.
- ☐ I do not rely on an open-door policy alone to surface problems.
- ☐ I actively seek information instead of waiting for it to come to me.

2. Run skip-levels to hear the ground truth

- ☐ I regularly meet with skip-level reports, not just my direct reports.
- ☐ I use skip-levels to learn, not to undermine the manager.
- ☐ I ask about team health, blockers, morale, and opportunities.
- ☐ I ask what is going well and what is not.
- ☐ I ask the team what support they need from management.
- ☐ I ask whether there are concerns about the manager, product direction, or coordination with other teams.
- ☐ I use both 1:1s and occasional group skip-level sessions where appropriate.

3. Hold managers accountable for team health and output

- ☐ I am clear that each manager is accountable for their team's health and productivity.
- ☐ I do not excuse chronic issues just because the environment is messy.
- ☐ I expect managers to bring me problems early, with context and proposed next steps.
- ☐ I coach managers, but I do not absorb the responsibility that belongs to them.
- ☐ I evaluate whether a manager is making my job easier in the right way, not by hiding problems.

4. Watch for failure patterns in managers

- ☐ I look for managers who overpromise and underdeliver.
- ☐ I watch for people-pleasing behavior and avoidance of hard conversations.
- ☐ I notice when managers shield teams from reality instead of solving root problems.
- ☐ I notice that when managers say yes to everyone and create confusion.
- ☐ I watch for control-freak or micromanaging behavior.
- ☐ I watch for managers who skip 1:1s, avoid feedback, or evade specifics.
- ☐ I address unhealthy patterns directly and early.

5. Support and inspect new managers closely

- ☐ I spend extra time coaching first-time managers.
- ☐ I check how their 1:1s, feedback, delegation, and planning are going.
- ☐ I make expectations explicit about delivery, team health, and accountability.
- ☐ I look for signs of overload, avoidance, or misuse of authority.
- ☐ I give corrective feedback in the first six months when needed.
- ☐ I provide access to training, mentoring, and practical support.

6. Manage experienced managers deliberately

- ☐ I assess whether experienced managers fit our culture and way of working.
- ☐ I do not confuse experience elsewhere with effectiveness here.
- ☐ I align with management philosophy, expectations, and team culture.
- ☐ I let experienced managers operate independently where appropriate.
- ☐ I coach them more on strategy, scope, influence, and organizational impact.

7. Hire managers with rigor

- ☐ I assess both management skill and cultural fit.
- ☐ I test how candidates run 1:1s and handle difficult people situations.
- ☐ I ask how they coach underperformers and grow strong performers.
- ☐ I ask about their management philosophy and delegation style.
- ☐ I check whether they can diagnose team problems, not just talk well.
- ☐ I evaluate the team they would manage as having sufficient technical credibility.
- ☐ I do thorough reference checks, including strengths, failures, and whether others would work with them again.

8. If managing outside my expertise, lean in harder

- ☐ I spend more time learning unfamiliar functions instead of fewer.

- ☐ I ask the manager and team to teach me how the work works.
- ☐ I have built enough understanding to detect problems and ask informed questions.
- ☐ I do not retreat into only the areas where I feel comfortable.
- ☐ I regularly check in on unfamiliar areas until I develop judgment.

9. Debug dysfunctional teams like systems problems

- ☐ I form a hypothesis about what might be wrong.
- ☐ I check the data: tickets, incidents, reviews, calendars, communication patterns, and delivery history.
- ☐ I observe the team in meetings and working sessions.
- ☐ I ask people whether they understand goals and why those goals matter.
- ☐ I assess team dynamics, collaboration, trust, and cross-functional relationships.
- ☐ I jump in to help when needed, especially if the manager is struggling.
- ☐ I stay curious and keep asking why until I understand the real issue.

10. Improve delivery and schedule communication

- I make sure teams produce estimates and update them when reality changes.
- I communicate schedule risk early, especially on important work.
- I help teams learn from bad estimates instead of treating estimation as a one-time activity.
- I distinguish real delays from leadership discomfort with uncertainty.
- I help cut scope when needed to protect important deadlines.
- I ensure managers, tech leads, and partners share a common view of progress.

11. Handle roadmap uncertainty realistically

- ☐ Plans may change, so avoid promising too much too early.
- ☐ I break great efforts into smaller deliverables that create value sooner.
- ☐ I avoid promising future technical work without a real commitment behind it.
- ☐ I reserve capacity for sustaining engineering, cleanup, bugs, and improvements.
- ☐ I ask teams to explain the size, value, and urgency of technical projects.
- ☐ I help teams make clean transitions when priorities or org structures change.

12. Stay technically relevant enough to lead well

- ☐ I understand the major systems, bottlenecks, and technical bets across my org.
- ☐ I read some code, reviews, or technical docs often enough to stay grounded.

- ☐ I ask engineers to teach me areas I do not understand.
- ☐ I attend postmortems and learn from failures.
- ☐ I stay informed about engineering tools, processes, and industry trends.
- ☐ I use my technical judgment to filter requests instead of acting as a relay between leadership and teams.
- ☐ I can explain technical tradeoffs in business terms.

13. Review myself as a manager-of-managers

- ☐ I know how often I engage skip-levels and whether it is enough.
- ☐ I can clearly describe what I expect from each manager's role.
- ☐ I know how I evaluate my managers.
- ☐ I have a current view of each manager's strengths, weaknesses, and development needs.
- ☐ I know which teams are running better than others and why.
- ☐ I can explain my process for hiring, coaching, and assessing managers.
- ☐ I am spending my time on leverage, not falling back into individual contributor or project-manager habits.